Positioning HBCUs in the Current Environment

Michelle Asha Cooper, PhD
President
mcooper@ihep.org

Leadership Summit
June 2012

IHEP

PRESENTED BY
The Institute for Higher Education Policy

About IHEP

Our Vision

- **The Institute for Higher Education Policy (IHEP) envisions a world where all people—particularly populations who have been underserved—have the opportunity to reach their full potential by participating and succeeding in higher education.**

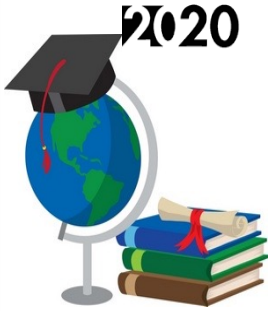
Our Mission

- **IHEP is committed to improving college access and success in higher education for all students—with a special focus on underserved populations—by providing timely research to inform public policy decisions.**

OVERVIEW OF THE HIGHER EDUCTION LANDSCAPE

PRESENTED BY
The Institute for Higher Education Policy

The College Completion Agenda



Obama Administration's Education Goal:

- **The President's Bold Goal: Have the highest proportion of college graduates in the world by 2020.**



The Lumina Foundation for Education:

- **Increase the percent of Americans with a two or four year degree from 37.9% to 60% by 2025**

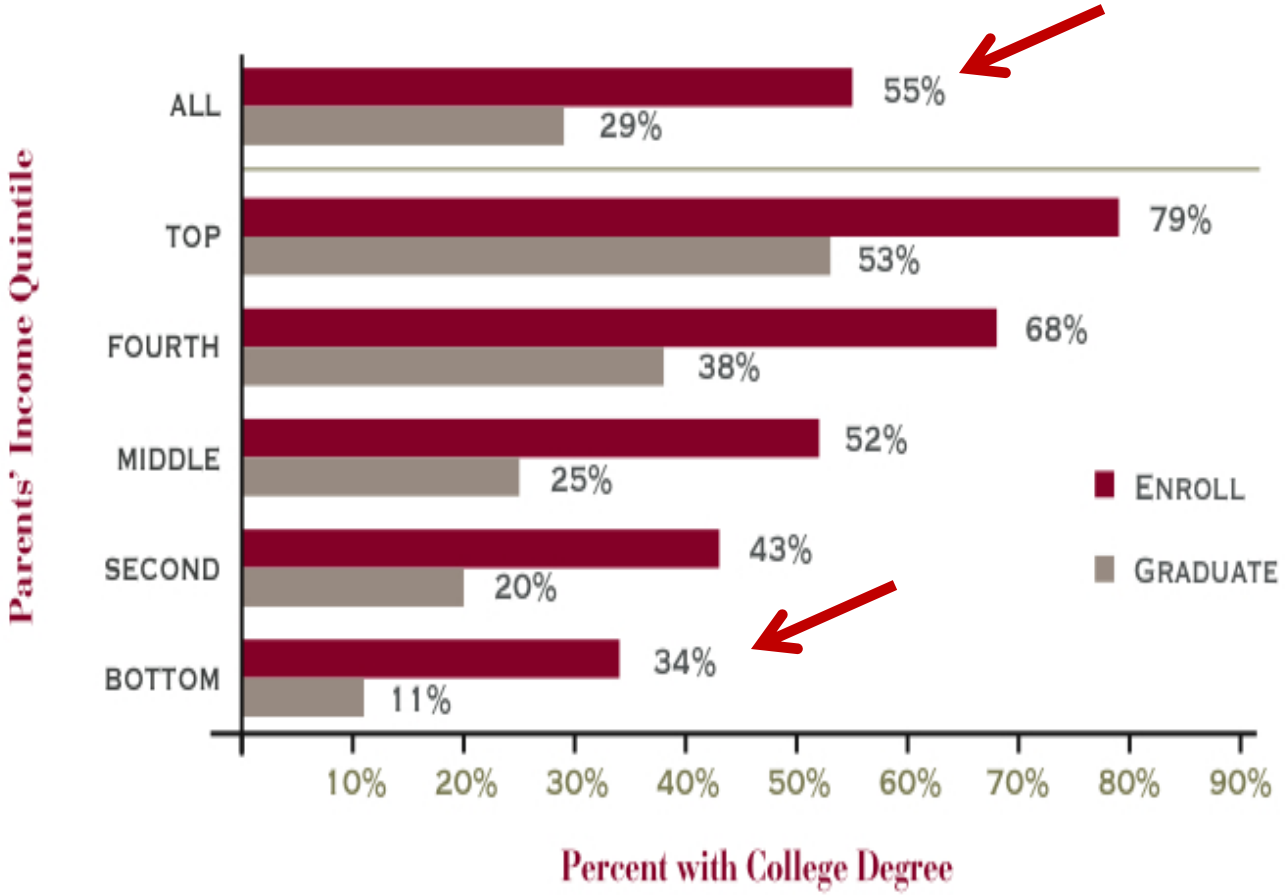


The College Board:

- **At least 55 percent of the U.S. population holds a college degree or certificate by 2025**

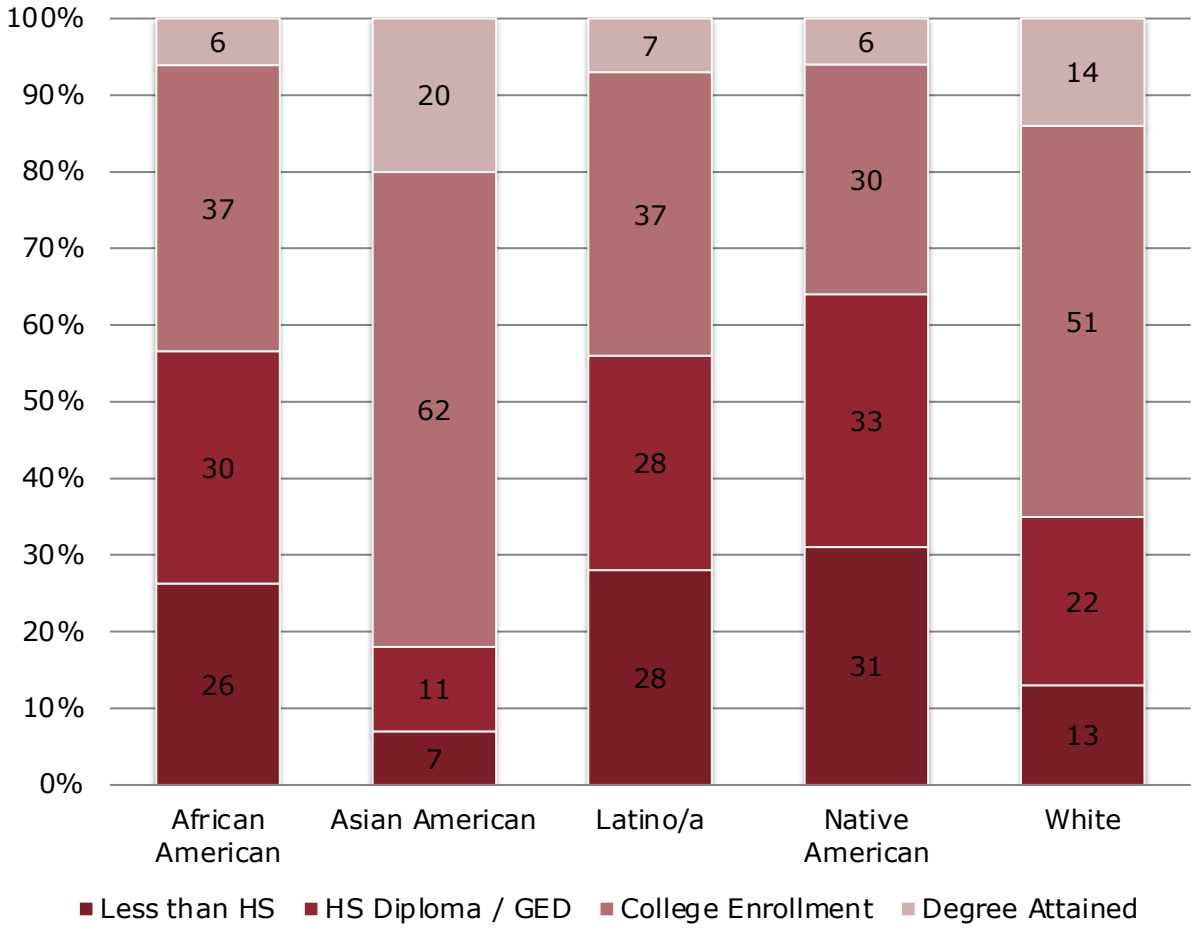
IHEP

Low-income children are less likely to enroll in college, less likely to graduate



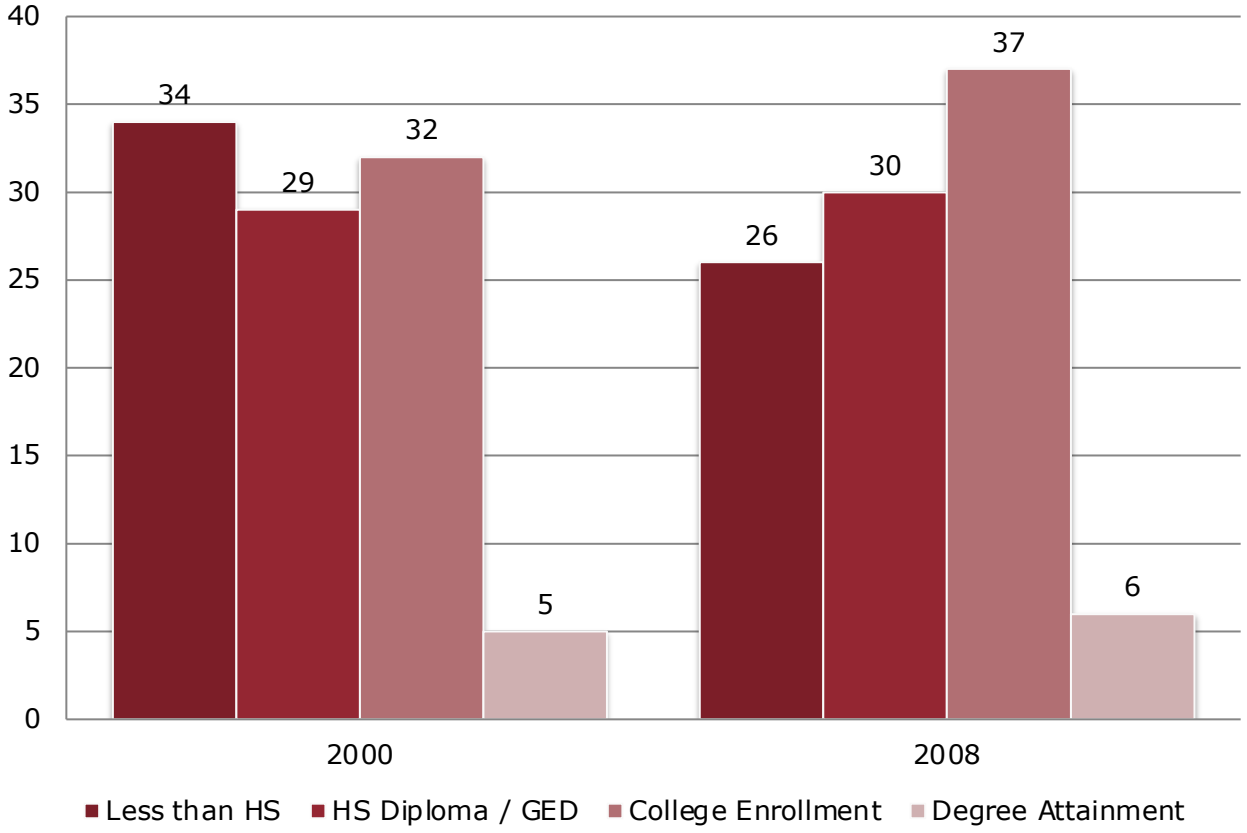
Source: Brookings tabulations using data from the Panel Study of Income Dynamics; See Haskins, 2008a

Highest Level of Attainment by Low-Income Young Adults, 2008 (by percent)



Source: IHEP (2010). Portraits of Low-Income Young Adults

Change in Highest Level of Attainment by African Americans, 2000 and 2008
(by percent)



Source: IHEP (2010). Portraits of Low-Income Young Adults

HBCUs within the Current Landscape

- **Enroll 11 percent of all African-American students**
- **Award approximately 22 percent of all bachelor's degrees to African Americans:**
  - **35 percent of astronomy, biology, chemistry, mathematics, and physics graduates**
  - **50 percent of all African American teachers**
  - **24 percent of all African American science and engineering graduates**

Source: Nelms, Charlie (2011). *Strengthening America's Historically Black Colleges and Universities: A Call to Action*.

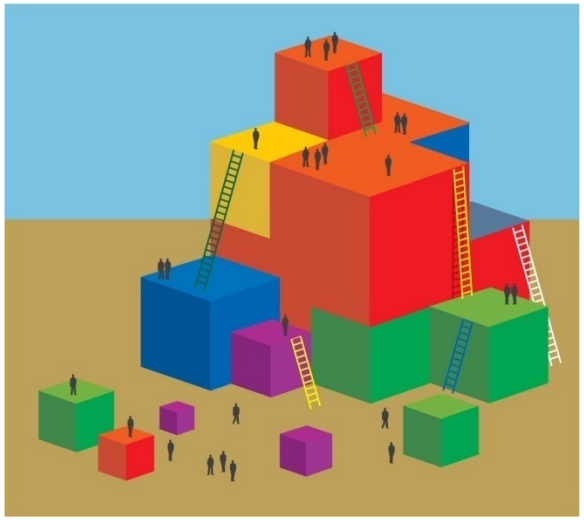
Drivers of the College Completion Agenda

- **Global Imperative**
  - Globalized knowledge economy
  - 21st Century consciousness
- **Economic Imperative**
  - Current labor market signals
  - Future workforce readiness
- **Equity Imperative**
  - Fastest-population growth occurring among racial/ethnic minorities
  - Growing need to reengage and retrain growing number of adult learners
  - Stratification along socioeconomic status

IHEP

Building Blocks for College Success

- **Academics**
- **Academic and Social Support Services**
- **Financial Assistance**



IHEP

Financial Need Contributes to Failure to Complete



Work/Loan Burden

Too much work

Stress

Housing and food insecurity

Too little sleep

Too little studying

Poor grades

Part-time enrollment

Failure to complete

Source: CLASP, 2011

(Proven) Promising Practices: Strategies that Support Student Success

- **Institutions should amplify their capacity to identify and track students, particularly those most at-risk**
- **Engage faculty early in the process and provide continuous support**
- **Embrace curricular change as a way to improve student success**
- **Institutions must ensure that promising practices are visible both internally and externally**
  - ❖ **Institutional leaders must be VOCAL participants in policy conversations, particularly those related to accountability and affordability**

Source: IHEP (forthcoming): *Supporting First-Generation College Students Through Classroom-Based Practices*

Recommendation 1:
Institutions should amplify their capacity to identify and track students, particularly those most at-risk

Evidence-Based Solutions an Holistic Approaches to Success Strategy		
STRATEGY	HOW	RESULT
Identifying the number of potentially at-risk students as a means to corroborate institutional efforts.	Create methods via admissions and orientation to ascertain specific number of students upon enrollment.	More targeted approach to the types of at-risk students.
Using qualitative and quantitative approaches to understanding and supporting first-generation students.	Use national and institutional-created data sets to track student outcomes.	Stronger programmatic design and institutionalization efforts.
Utilizing traditional research modeling and design to track effective practices and first-generation students progression.	Use interviews and focus groups to enhance anecdotal understanding.	Stronger analysis and evidence of what works.
Thinking beyond standard measures of success.	Examine nonstandard measures of student learning (noncognitive, self-regulation, etc.).	More holistic approach to engagement and learning.

Source: IHEP (forthcoming): *Supporting First-Generation College Students Through Classroom-Based Practices (graphic modified)*

Recommendation 2:
Engage faculty early in the process and provide continuous support

Faculty as Key Allies		
STRATEGY	HOW	RESULT
Formalizing and reinforcing changes to faculty roles as related to student success.	Required professional development sessions. Scholarly and collaborative faculty learning communities.	Unique inter- and intradisciplinary exchanges. Greater cohesion around student success goals and learning outcomes.
Formalizing and reinforcing changes to faculty roles as related to student success.	Explicit language to support at-risk students in faculty position descriptions. Formal recognition as part of performance evaluations and incentives..	Clearer expectations of faculty roles inside and outside of the classroom. Stronger interest and ownership in participating in student-related success initiatives and programs.
Engaging faculty in disciplines and departments where students traditionally struggle.	Identify high-enrollment, high-failure courses. Allow faculty in specific departments determine the types of academic and social supports needed.	Stronger student performance and pass rates. Greater faculty ownership of creating a more engaging classroom environment.

Source: IHEP (forthcoming): *Supporting First-Generation College Students Through Classroom-Based Practices (graphic modified)*

Recommendation 3: Embrace curricular change as a way to improve student success

Curricular and Pedagogical Redesign		
STRATEGY	HOW	RESULT
Redesigning developmental and/or general education as a means to advance students to discipline-specific courses.	Introduce high-impact practices into developmental/general education delivery. Consider new tools and assessment measures to refine student placement and intake.	Renewed and/or reformed approaches to the delivery of remedial and general education. Stronger student performance and pass rates.
Embedding supplemental services such as instructors and peer tutors.	Train peer learning facilitators/instructors to serve as additional classroom mentors. Embed supplemental instruction in specific high-failure courses.	Stronger student pass rates. Stronger faculty-student relationships. A more accountable and engaging classroom environment.
Introducing and including culturally relevant material into classroom practices.	Integrate specific cultural characteristics from the local community and students. Establish forums for cultural exchanges and awareness.	More inclusive and attuned classroom practices to engage students. More engaging and applied curriculum.

Source: IHEP (forthcoming): *Supporting First-Generation College Students Through Classroom-Based Practices (graphic modified)*

Recommendation 4:
Institutions must ensure that promising practices are visible both internally and externally

Building Partnerships and External Allies to Highlight Student Success		
STRATEGY	HOW	RESULT
Institutionalizing the recognition of student success on campus.	Public and institutional presence centered on the needs of at-risk students (Web-based, mission statement, etc.).	Broad recognition and acceptance of at-risk students, internally and externally.
Establishing classroom activities that relate to the larger community	Classroom and learning themes related to community or global issues.	More applied student learning and understanding of material. New and stronger connections with community organizations.
Disseminating success stories on and beyond the campus.	Participating in campus meetings and presenting at national education-related conferences to garner interest among peer institutions. Conducting interviews with media outlets to disseminate project results to broader audience.	Stronger external acknowledgment of project work and support. More peer institution connections and exchanges that build on capacity and scalability.

Source: IHEP (forthcoming): *Supporting First-Generation College Students Through Classroom-Based Practices (graphic modified)*